

What is Intelligence?

A first-semester class, in fourteen weeks, that answers its title with a definition — and earns it.

[↑ Introduction to Computer Science](#)

proof • notation • syntax • truth • meaning • semantics

WHAT THIS CLASS IS FOR

A deep understanding of the basic principles — deep enough to **position generative AI**, and whatever comes next, properly.

Not how to use a device. Not how to prompt a chat bot. Not even, mainly, how to code.

The principles were true before this technology arrived and will be true after whatever replaces it. That is why nothing in this class mentions a product, a vendor, or a year.

By the end you can say, about any machine that talks, exactly what it is and what it cannot be — and check the answer yourself.

THE QUESTION

Is it intelligent? — badly posed, as the talk said. We replace it with questions you can answer: what language, what semantics, what metric, what budget, who checks.

THE SHORT ANSWER

Intelligence is developing new formal languages — or new properties in existing ones — which requires discovering and understanding promising *unproven* truth. Fourteen weeks to earn it.

Everything in this class sits somewhere on **one line**.



the six stations of this book, on its one axis

the six stations of the semester

Finite. Bits, and how fast a few of them outnumber the atoms in the universe. Week 2 and 3.

Countable. Everything you can write down: programs, proofs, machines — and the machine that reads them. Weeks 4 to 6.

Uncountable. What you mean by it. Behaviours, truths. Cantor, Gödel, Turing, Rice — then the compiler and the operating system built anyway. Weeks 7 to 10. Then cost, machines, and the answer.

The route.

WK		LECTURE	IN THE TERMINAL
1	–	The talk, then the class	./selfie
2	I	Size: bits, state spaces	–c selfie.c
3	I	Everything is bits	examples/
4	II	Notation: EBNF, C*, RISC-U	–s
5	II	Countability; the fixed point	make self-self-check
6	II	The machine: RISC-U, mipster	make emu, –d
7	III	Uncountability: the diagonal	–

WK		LECTURE	IN THE TERMINAL
8	III	Self-reference I: Gödel	make self
9	III	Self-reference II: halting, Rice	–d on a loop
10	III	Systems: emulation $\equiv$ virtualization	make os-emu
11	IV	Cost: P vs NP, SAT, Landauer	make sat
12	IV	Formal methods: rotor, bitme	make rotor
13	V	Machines: LLMs, the gate	a prompt
14	VI	What is intelligence?	–

One file, small enough to read to the end: **selfie**.

A compiler for a tiny subset of C, an emulator for a tiny subset of RISC-V, and a hypervisor — twelve thousand lines, one file, written in the language it compiles.

Three commands: the compiler compiles itself, the emulator executes itself, the hypervisor hosts itself. Understand the first and you understand compilers; the second, machines; the third, operating systems.

And a workshop of tools around it that turn a program into a logical formula and hand it to a solver — where this class meets the frontier, in week 12.

```
$ ./selfie -c selfie.c -o selfie0.m -m 3 \
    -c selfie.c -o selfie1.m
./selfie: selfie compiling selfie.c
to 64-bit RISC-U with 64-bit starc
...
./selfie: 64-bit mipster executing
64-bit RISC-U binary selfie0.m
with 3MB physical memory
> selfie0.m: selfie compiling selfie.c
to 64-bit RISC-U with 64-bit starc
...
$ diff -s selfie0.m selfie1.m
Files selfie0.m and selfie1.m are identical
```

Install selfie, and run it once.

- 1 Get a terminal. Every laptop has one; if you only have a browser, the repository's README shows the cloud option.
- 2 Download selfie from `github.com/cksystemsteaching/selfie` and type make in its directory. You need a C compiler; the README says which.
- 3 Type `./selfie`. It answers with its synopsis, one line, in a formal language. Bring that line to week 2.
- 4 Read the introduction of the book, and the Selfie chapter, and type the two commands in it.

THE BOOK

What is Intelligence? — this class is its first six parts at talk resolution, one chapter per week or so. It is in the repository under `book/`.

EXERCISES

This class has no formal assignments. It has a recommended exercise list per week: reading, the commands of the session to rerun, a few paper exercises. Whoever wants more can try the first autograded assignments of the compiler and systems classes.

Slow yourself down.

Formal languages are not casual. Everything matters, even the tiniest detail, and the trick to learning them is to take steps so small they are almost painful.

Every negative result in this class — there are five — is read twice: what it forbids, and what it opens. The second reading is the one to remember.

Whatever intelligence is, humour is the only way.

THE LAST SLIDE OF THE TALK, AND OF WEEK 14

Listen, then read.

LISTEN

Beethoven · Symphony No. 3 “Eroica” — Bernstein, Vienna Philharmonic. A symphony that invented a new language for the form — twice the length of anything before it, and every later symphony is written in the language it made. The definition, in E flat.

READ

Gödel, Escher, Bach — Hofstadter, 1979: Gödel, Bach and Escher as three renderings of one loop, the book this class’s spine grew out of. And, more technical, On the cruelty of really teaching computing science — Dijkstra, 1988: why the small steps are not optional.